

of operating rigid airships as passenger and mail carriers on imperial routes to Canada, India, and Australia. Two airships were built, the R 100 and R 101. Although the R 100 was an airworthy craft that flew to Canada and back in the summer of 1930, the government-built R 101 was a thoroughly bad design – overweight, leaky, and short of lift. But Britain's Secretary of State for air, Lord Thomson, insisted that the airship was “safe as a house” and commanded that its maiden flight take place in October 1930. The R 101 was to carry Thomson and other senior officials from England to India. It got no further than Beauvais, in northern France. Out of control on a night of wind and rain, the airship crashed into a hillside, killing all but six of the 54 people on board, including Thomson.

The tragic fiasco of the R 101 ended Britain's airship program and the R 100 was broken up for scrap. France, whose inventors and sportsmen had once led the world in lighter-than-air flight, had also dropped out after the *Dixmude*, an adaptation of the L 72, broke up in a storm over the Mediterranean in 1923. Italy also abandoned airship development after Umberto Nobile's *Italia* was lost during an Arctic expedition in 1928.

The Graf Zeppelin

In the end, the Germans were the only Europeans with the knowledge and experience required to design and operate airships. And the German people continued to see their zeppelins as proud symbols of their country's technological prowess. In 1925, when Hugo Eckener decided to build an airship capable of operating a transatlantic passenger service, he raised the money by public subscription, appealing to national sentiment exactly as Count von Zeppelin had done after the crash of the LZ 4 back in 1908.

The result was the *Graf Zeppelin*, the most successful airship of all time. First flown in September 1928, it was one of the largest

AROUND THE WORLD IN 21 DAYS

IN THE SUMMER OF 1929, Zeppelin boss Hugo Eckener staged a sensational demonstration of the *Graf Zeppelin*'s potential by making the first passenger-carrying flight around the earth. The 19th-century fantasy writer Jules Verne had imagined a race to circle the globe in 80 days; the airship would do it in three weeks. Early in the morning of August 8, the *Graf Zeppelin* left Lakehurst, New Jersey, carrying 16 passengers and 37 crew members. Heading east across the Atlantic, it reached the Zeppelin base in Friedrichshafen in southern Germany at lunchtime on August 10. After a rest and some sightseeing, the passengers re-embarked for a 7,029-mile (11,247-km) nonstop flight to Tokyo, crossing the sparsely populated wastes of Siberia. The captain would occasionally drop the airship down for a closer look at places of interest along the route. The inevitable tedious stretches were alleviated by a constantly changing menu that matched the countries traversed – Rhine salmon over Germany, beluga caviar over Russia.

After a few days in Tokyo, where the passengers and crew enjoyed a tumultuous welcome, the *Graf Zeppelin* set off across the Pacific to Los Angeles. After a one-night stop in California, the airship was on its way east again, reaching Lakehurst on the morning of August 29. The journey had taken 21 days, 5 hours, and 31 minutes. Eckener was invited to the White House to meet President Hoover and the whole crew was treated to a ticketape parade down Broadway.

ARRIVAL IN JAPAN

The Graf Zeppelin is viewed by curious visitors in its hangar in Tokyo, Japan, after completing the second leg of the world tour – a nonstop, 102-hour, 7,029-mile (11,247-km) flight.

machines ever to fly. It had the latest in aviation instruments, including radio direction-finding, but most striking was the quality of travel experience it offered its 20 passengers. The passenger section of the gondola was quiet and reasonably spacious, and the temperature was comfortable. Eckener did all he could to stress the luxury and glamour of the *Graf Zeppelin*. In the spring of 1929, a clutch of German dignitaries were taken on a magical voyage over the Mediterranean and the Near East, lapping up costly wines and haute cuisine meals while the sights of Rome, Capri, Crete, Cyprus, and Palestine filled the picture windows.

But the emphasis on glamour was a deliberate distraction from some of the Zeppelin's serious drawbacks. It was a vast vehicle to transport

only 20 paying customers; traveling at about 60mph (100kph), it was also fairly slow; and it could not comfortably cope with the weather in the North Atlantic. Instead of linking Germany to New York, the *Graf Zeppelin* settled into a scheduled service across the South Atlantic to Brazil, where a well-heeled German expatriate community provided a sufficient pool of customers.

Despite the drawbacks of the *Graf Zeppelin*, in the early 1930s, faith in the future of airship travel was riding high. Germany embarked on the construction of an



HAUTE CUISINE

The Hindenburg dining tables were set with linen tablecloths, china, silverware, and glassware. Stewards served passengers gourmet meals and fine wines from the galley.



SIGHTSEEING

This poster shows the Hindenburg over Manhattan. Good views of sights like the Empire State Building were expected by passengers.